CADRE

Charter, Authority, Decision Rights, Records, Escalation. The Governance Function Specified as Five Artifacts

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Registry entry: REG-07 of the Defensible AI Framework Registry [3]. The identifier is unchanged by the rename recorded at Appendix A.

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Status. This is a specification, not a certification scheme. No conformity assessment body operates against it, and no institution can be certified against it. Section 8 states what a conformance claim means and what it does not.

Abstract

A board grants a mandate for AI governance and the institution announces a function. Some months later a supervisor asks a question the announcement cannot answer: under what authority was that system released, who exercised it, and where is the record. That gap is not a documentation gap. It is that the mandate was never converted into anything the institution can produce on demand.

This specification defines **CADRE™**, the AI Governance Operating Model: the structure, decision rights and cadence of the AI governance function, specified as five artifacts an auditor can test. **C**harter, **A**uthority, **D**ecision rights, **R**ecords, **E**scalation. Each is drawn from the framework's registry entry, not fitted to a letter. On the name gives the derivation.

The purpose is narrow and load-bearing. It is **to convert a mandate into authority that is exercised on a schedule and recorded**, which is the difference between a governance function and a governance intention. Two properties distinguish it from an organization chart. **Exactly one person is accountable per decision**, and an assignment naming a committee as accountable does not satisfy the requirement. And **a cadence with no meeting records is not a cadence**. The record is the artifact, including the record of a meeting cancelled and why. The calendar is not.

CADRE holds a position in the governance family no other framework holds. It is **the sole authority source in the register**, granting authority to model risk management, data governance, vendor risk, incident response and the deployment spine, and the register published at [3] carries no edge whose target is CADRE. What returns to it is an escalation record it writes itself. A framework that granted authority and also consumed evidence from those it granted it to would be marking its own work.

The specification states what would falsify the framework: that institutions operating a chartered office with a single-accountable decision-rights assignment and a recorded cadence escalate AI risks no earlier, and resolve

them no more consistently, than institutions handling AI governance inside existing risk committees. **No institution unconnected to the author has been observed operating it**, and no charter, decision-rights or cadence templates are published with it. Section 10 states each of those plainly.

Keywords: AI governance; governance operating model; decision rights; accountability; three lines model; governance cadence; escalation; charter; evidence architecture; regulated industries; CADRE.

On the name

CADRE stands for **Charter, Authority, Decision rights, Records, Escalation**. The five terms name the artifacts the framework produces, and each is drawn from the framework's registry entry [3] rather than fitted to the letters.

- **Charter.** The first output the entry lists and the first evidence requirement it states: a charter, dated and approved by the body that granted the mandate. It is first in both lists. Nothing below it is defensible without it. An office operating without a dated charter is an office whose authority cannot be traced to the body that supposedly granted it.
- **Authority.** The entry's stated purpose is to convert a mandate into authority that is exercised on a schedule and recorded. Authority is also what the framework moves. It is the only framework in the register that grants authority, and it grants it to five others.
- **Decision rights.** The second of the three parts of the entry's definition, stated there in the same words. The assignment, per lifecycle phase and per decision type, of who is accountable, who is responsible, who is consulted and who is informed, with exactly one person accountable per decision.
- **Records.** The entry's evidence requirement turns on a single rule: a cadence with no meeting records is not a cadence. The records are what the cadence produces and are the reason the cadence is in the framework at all.
- **Escalation.** The last output the entry lists, and the one another framework consumes. The escalation paths on which incidents, human-review tiers and gate disputes terminate are supplied to the incident response protocol, REG-05, as the routes along which an incident travels.

Read in reverse, the five give the order in which an incident tests the function. An escalation is examined first, because an escalation is what an incident produces. The records make it reconstructible. The decision rights say who wrote them and who was answerable. The authority says whether that person could bind the institution. The charter says where that authority came from.

The five terms are not the three parts of the definition. The registry defines the framework in three parts: Structure, Decision rights and Cadence. Those three remain the definition. The five artifacts are what those parts produce and are the form in which the framework is testable. Decision rights appears in both lists because it is both a part of the definition and an artifact. Structure produces the Charter and the Authority, and Cadence produces the Records and the Escalation. No other correspondence is intended.

The ordinary meaning of the word is the thing being named. A cadre is the nucleus of trained personnel around which an organization is built. That is what a governance office is, and the name says so without a metaphor.

The former name

Through registry version 1.0 this framework was named **the AI Governance Operating Model**, and was deliberately unmarked. **That phrase survives as the descriptor and is retired only as the name.** First mention in any document is *CADRE™, the AI Governance Operating Model*; subsequent mentions are *CADRE*. The short form recorded at the registry entry, *the Operating Model*, is replaced by *CADRE*.

The reasoning that kept the framework unmarked is rewritten at Appendix A.4 rather than deleted, because the question it recorded as open is now closed and the record of why it was open is part of the answer.

A newly coined name invites the charge that it was retrofitted to five convenient letters. The defence is the derivation above rather than a denial.

One disambiguation that survives the rename

The MESA Framework specification names the first pillar of its third layer, Operational Machinery, **Governance operating model**, and states explicitly that **pillar 1 is not the AI Governance Operating Model** [1]. That disambiguation is carried forward here without weakening, and the rename does not resolve it by accident.

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MESA pillar 1 is the Layer 3 control family in which an institution's governance structure produces records: the accountability matrix, the deployment gate records, the committee charter, cadence and minutes, and the three-lines allocation for AI. CADRE is the framework that constitutes the structure and allocates the rights, and the registry places it at the Strategic Compass because that is the altitude at which an institution chooses what to grant. Authority is constituted at Layer 2 and evidenced at Layer 3. That is the cascade MESA specifies and not a disagreement about altitude.

The practical rule is unchanged. A reader who encounters the phrase *governance operating model* inside a MESA layer table is reading a control family. A reader who encounters *CADRE™, the AI Governance Operating Model* is reading this framework. Where this specification and the registry describe the same relationship, **the registry governs the framework's place in the architecture and this specification governs what the framework requires** [3].

What CADRE is not

Stated at the front so a reader can establish the boundary before investing in the detail. CADRE is not:

- an organization chart, or a recommendation about reporting lines;
- a specification of the competencies, training or credentials of the people in the function;
- a replacement for the three lines model, which it positions the AI function within rather than restates;
- a replacement for ISO/IEC 42001 or the NIST AI Risk Management Framework;
- a certification scheme, and no accredited body assesses against it;
- a statement of regulatory compliance, which only a supervisor can make;
- an empirically validated instrument. Section 10 states precisely what has not been tested.

Notation

This specification uses **MUST**, **MUST NOT**, **SHOULD**, **SHOULD NOT** and **MAY** as the normative verbal forms.

- **MUST** indicates a requirement. A function that does not meet it is not conformant with this specification.
- **SHOULD** indicates a recommendation. Departure requires a recorded rationale.
- **MAY** indicates a permission.

The MESA Framework specification [1] and A Pattern Language for Production LLM Platforms [2] use the verbal forms of ISO/IEC Directives Part 2, in which **shall** carries the meaning assigned to MUST here. The correspondence is exact.

Defined terms

Mandate. The instrument by which a board or equivalent governing body directs that an AI governance function exist. A mandate is an instruction. It is not itself authority, and 2.1 states the difference.

Charter. The dated instrument, approved by the body that granted the mandate, that constitutes the governance function, states its scope, and enumerates the authority it holds.

The office. The staffed governance function the charter constitutes. Called the AI governance office throughout. An institution MAY name it otherwise; the name is not normative and the artifacts are.

Decision type. A class of decision recurring across the AI lifecycle for which a standing allocation of accountability is possible: a release, a classification, an exception, a retirement, an escalation acceptance.

Accountable person. The single named individual answerable for a decision type. Distinct from the responsible person, who performs the work, and from those consulted and informed.

Escalation path. A named route by which a matter leaves the level at which it arose and reaches one that can decide it, with a named recipient, a stated threshold and a stated clock.

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Institution. The accountable legal entity operating the AI systems. **Regulated institution** means one whose ability to operate is conditioned on its ability to reconstruct and defend a decision to an external authority.

Sections 2 through 8 are normative. Sections 1, 9, 10 and 11 are informative, except where they state a requirement using **MUST**.

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1. Introduction

1.1 The problem

Most institutions that govern AI have a governance function on paper before they have one in fact, and the distance between the two is invisible from inside. A steering committee is convened. A policy is published. A slide names four workstreams and an owner for each. Nothing in that sequence is dishonest, and none of it produces an artifact a supervisor can hold.

The failure has a recognizable shape. Asked who approved a particular model into production, the institution produces the minutes of a committee that noted it. Asked under what authority the committee acted, it produces a terms-of-reference document nobody dated. Asked what the function reviewed in the quarter before the incident, it produces a calendar rather than the records of the meetings that calendar promised. Three of those meetings did not happen.

A mandate is not authority. It is permission to construct authority. The construction is the work. It consists of a small number of artifacts that either exist or do not: an instrument saying what the function may bind, an allocation saying which person binds it for which decision, and a record saying when they last did.

1.2 What this framework proposes

That the governance function itself be specified with the discipline it applies to the systems it governs. The frameworks around it require evidence of a validation, a classification, a vendor clearance. CADRE requires evidence of itself.

Three parts, formerly asserted as three separate frameworks and consolidated into one at registry section 6.2 [3]. **Structure**: the office, its roles, its staffing, its reporting lines, and its position within the three lines model [8]. **Decision rights**: the allocation, per lifecycle phase and per decision type, of who is accountable, responsible, consulted and informed. **Cadence**: the rhythm on which the function operates, together with the escalation paths on which incidents, human-review tiers and gate disputes terminate.

The three answer three questions about one subject: how the function is organized, who decides within it, and how often it meets. A decision-rights matrix has no operational meaning without a structure to assign rights within. A cadence has none without either.

1.3 Contribution

1. **Five artifacts specified as testable**, stated as requirements rather than as descriptions of good practice. Sections 2 through 6.
2. **A single accountable person per decision, stated as a MUST**, with the prohibition on committee accountability worked through. Section 4.
3. **The record rule**, under which a cancelled meeting produces a record and a cadence producing none is not operating. Section 5.
4. **The authority position stated explicitly**: what CADRE grants, and why nothing flows back. Section 3.
5. **A ninety-day stand-up path** with four ordered milestones and an artifact at each. Section 7.

1.4 Scope

The framework specifies the AI governance function of an institution operating AI systems under institutional accountability. It is calibrated to regulated institutions. 10.4 states what changes for one too small to staff it as described.

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1.5 Non-goals

- **Not an organization design method.** The framework states what the structure must produce, not which of the hub, network or hybrid shapes an institution should adopt.
- **Not a competency framework.** What the people in the office must know, what training they need and what credentials they hold are outside it, and 10.6 records that as a scope limitation rather than an omission.
- **Not a specification of the frameworks it grants authority to.** What a validation must contain and what a gate must require belong to those frameworks and are catalogued at [3].
- **Not a certification scheme.** No conformity assessment body operates against this specification.
- **Not an empirical claim.** Section 10 states what has not been tested.

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2. The Charter (Normative)

2.1 Authority is granted, and the grant is dated

The governance function MUST hold a charter, dated and approved by the body that granted its mandate. A function operating without one is not conformant with this specification, whatever its activity.

The requirement is not ceremonial. A supervisor arriving after a failure does not ask whether the institution took AI governance seriously. The question is whether the person who accepted a particular risk held the authority to accept it on the day they accepted it, and that question is answerable only against an instrument carrying a date and an approver. A charter that cannot be dated is a charter whose authority cannot be located in time.

A charter approved by the function itself, or by an executive on the function's behalf, does not satisfy this section. **The approver MUST be the body that granted the mandate**, because authority cannot be self-granted and a function that granted itself its own scope has recorded an ambition.

2.2 What the charter MUST contain

At minimum:

1. **The mandate it derives from**, identified and dated.
2. **The scope**: which AI systems, which business units and which jurisdictions the function governs, and what it does not.
3. **The authority the function holds**, enumerated by decision type. Where the function can stop a release, the charter MUST say so in those words. Where it can only advise, the charter MUST say that instead.
4. **The named head of the function**, who is the accountable role for this framework, and the reporting line.
5. **The position of the function within the three lines** [8], stated as an allocation rather than as a diagram: what the first line owns, what the function challenges, and what internal audit assures.
6. **The escalation destination**: the body or person to which the function escalates what it cannot resolve, and the standing under which that body receives it.
7. **The review date**, per 2.3.

A charter enumerating responsibilities without enumerating authority is the most common defective form. It produces a function answerable for outcomes it cannot bind. That is the precondition of governance theatre. It is visible in the document before it is visible in the behaviour.

2.3 The annual refresh

The charter MUST be reviewed and re-approved at least annually by the body that approved it, and the re-approval MUST be recorded whether or not the text changed.

An unchanged charter re-approved is evidence that the granting body still holds the position it took. A charter nobody has looked at in three years is evidence of nothing except that it was written once. The refresh is the mechanism by which a scope that has quietly drifted, because the institution deployed into a jurisdiction or a business the charter does not name, is either corrected or knowingly accepted.

Where the refresh is missed, the function is not thereby unchartered. **It is conformant with this specification only until the review date passes**, and 8.5 states the effect on a claim.

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2.4 Evidence

The charter itself, carrying the date and the approver, together with the record of each annual re-approval. **The charter is the framework's first evidence artifact and its absence cannot be compensated by any other.**

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3. Authority (Normative)

3.1 What the framework grants, and to whom

CADRE is the **sole authority source in the governance family**. The register of relationships published at registry section 5.2 records it as granting authority to five frameworks [3]:

Grantee	Registry entry	What the grant conveys
Model risk management	REG-02	The standing of the validation function, and the independence its challenge depends on
Data governance	REG-03	The authority to classify, and to refuse a use of data the classification forbids
Vendor risk	REG-04	The authority to clear or decline a vendor, and the standing to hold a contract term
Incident response	REG-05	The authority to declare an incident, and the escalation paths along which it routes
The deployment spine	REG-06	Release authority, exercised at the gates by the persons the decision-rights assignment names

An institution MUST NOT operate any of the five as a self-authorizing function. A validation function whose independence rests on its own assertion of it is not independent, and a gate whose approver was selected at the moment the gate was reached selected an approver willing to pass it.

The grant says what a framework may do, not how it does it. Where a grantee has a deposited instrument, that instrument governs the exercise: the vendor clearance authorized here is exercised through the due-diligence questionnaire at [6], and the dual-validation closure admitted at the third gate is specified at [5]. **CADRE authorizes; it does not specify the work.**

3.2 Nothing flows back, and the asymmetry is deliberate

The register carries no edge whose target is CADRE. What returns to the framework is **an escalation record it writes itself** rather than an artifact another framework produces [3].

This is a property rather than an omission. A framework that granted authority to five others and also consumed their evidence as an input to its own operation would be assessing work performed under authority it issued. The separation is what allows the escalation record to be read as the function exercising its own authority rather than as a summary of the frameworks reporting to it.

The consequence for an institution is concrete. **The function's own evidence MUST be producible without reference to the frameworks it governs.** An institution that can describe its governance function only by listing the validations performed and the gates passed underneath it has not evidenced the function. It has evidenced the frameworks the function authorized.

3.3 The structure that holds the authority

The charter MUST constitute a staffed office, and the office MUST carry the following named leads, each occupiable by one person:

- the **head of the AI governance office**, who is the accountable role for this framework;
- a **model risk lead**;
- a **data lead**;
- a **vendor lead**;

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- an **incident lead**;
- a **Sharia liaison**, where the institution operates under a Sharia Supervisory Board and REG-08 applies [5].

One person MAY hold more than one lead where scale requires it, and **the charter MUST record which leads are combined and why**. Two combinations are forbidden. The model risk lead MUST NOT be accountable for the release decision that relies on their validation, which is the separation the deployment spine requires at its second and third gates [4]. The incident lead MUST NOT be accountable for the systems whose incidents they classify.

The role set is the one the registry entry states, and deliberately not that of the source treatment. Appendix A.6 records the difference rather than reconciling it silently.

3.4 The three-lines position

The charter MUST allocate the function to a line and MUST state the allocation as ownership rather than as involvement. The three lines model was refreshed by its issuer in 2026 and now emphasizes the distinct contribution of each role rather than a defensive posture [8]. What this section requires is a statement of who owns what, which that change does not disturb.

The function normally sits in the second line: it sets policy, it challenges the first line's risk acceptance, and it is assured by the third. An institution MAY place it elsewhere and **MUST record why**, because a function placed in the first line has no challenge standing and a function placed in the third cannot set policy without compromising the assurance it provides.

An allocation in which more than one line owns the same activity is not an allocation. Where the charter records a shared activity, it MUST name which line is accountable and which is contributing.

3.5 Evidence

The charter clauses enumerating authority and the three-lines allocation. The staffing record naming each lead and any combination. **A named lead who cannot be identified by name on the day the evidence is requested is not a named lead.**

3.6 Figure 1: the authority cascade

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4. Decision Rights (Normative)

4.1 Exactly one person is accountable per decision

Every decision type MUST have exactly one accountable person, and that person MUST be a named individual. A committee, a function, a team, a board or a role held jointly MUST NOT be recorded as accountable.

The reasoning is stated once for the family at 3.3 of [3] and is not restated. What this framework adds is the granularity. The rule binds per decision type. An institution holding one accountable name for AI governance as a whole has satisfied the registry and not this section, because the decision an authority asks about is always a particular one.

A decision-rights assignment naming a committee as accountable satisfies neither this specification nor the registry requirement at 3.3 that governs every entry in the family [3].

4.2 What a committee may hold

The prohibition is on accountability, not on committees, and the distinction matters because most institutions arrive at this framework with committees already constituted.

A committee **MAY** be the forum in which a decision is deliberated, the body that must be consulted before it is taken, the body that receives it, or the body a rejected proposal appeals to. Where a committee performs any of those, the assignment MUST record it in the consulted or informed column and MUST name an individual in the accountable column.

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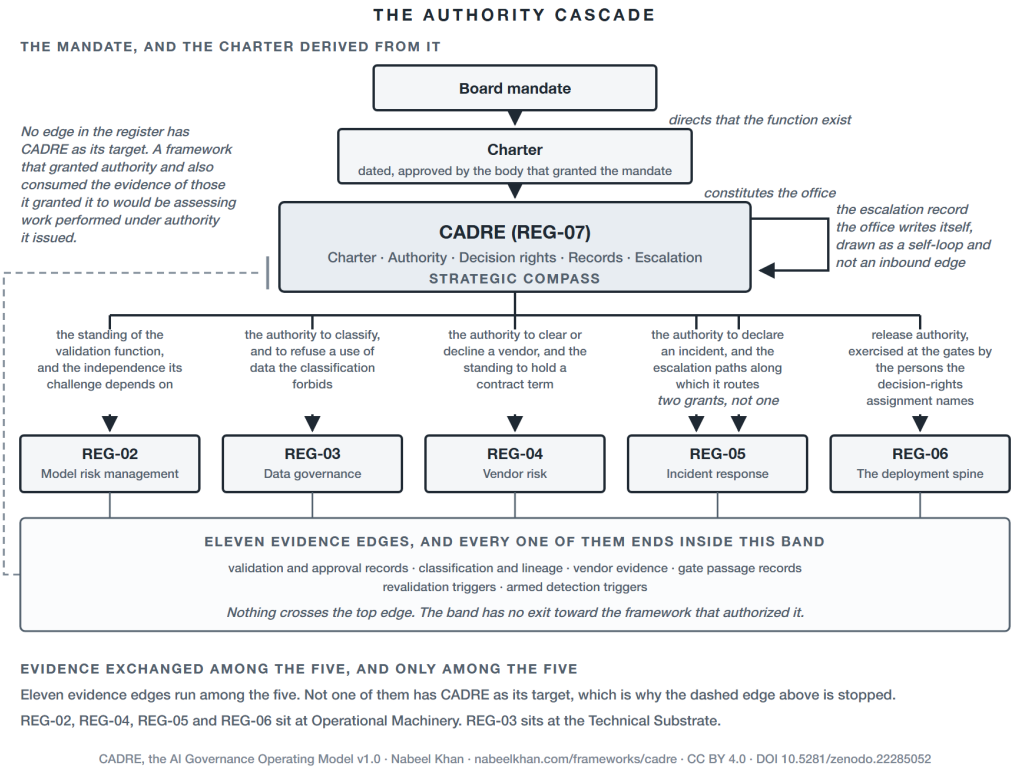


Figure 1. The authority cascade, and the absence of a return path. CADRE (REG-07) sits at the Strategic Compass altitude, below the board mandate and the charter derived from it. One authority fan runs outward to five frameworks at Operational Machinery and the Technical Substrate: model risk management (REG-02), data governance (REG-03), vendor risk (REG-04), incident response (REG-05) and the deployment spine (REG-06), each edge labelled with what the grant conveys. A second outbound edge carries the escalation paths and records to REG-05 alone. **No edge in the figure points at CADRE.** The five grantees exchange evidence densely among themselves, shown as a band beneath the fan, and none of it reaches the framework that authorized them; what returns to CADRE is the escalation record it writes itself, drawn as a self-loop rather than an inbound edge. The asymmetry is the visual subject, because a framework that granted authority and also consumed the evidence of those it granted it to would be assessing work performed under authority it issued. DOI https://doi.org/10.6084/m9.figshare.33420154

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Where an institution wishes a committee decision to bind, the committee chair is the accountable person, named as an individual, and the charter MUST say so. That is the honest form of the arrangement most institutions already operate, and writing it down is the whole of the change required.

4.3 The assignment is per lifecycle phase and per decision type

The assignment MUST be two-dimensional. One dimension is the phase of the AI lifecycle. The other is the decision type. A single list of roles against a single list of phases collapses the two and produces an assignment in which the same person appears accountable for a classification and for a release, which are different decisions with different consequences and frequently different holders.

The assignment MUST be complete over the decision types the charter enumerates. **A decision type the charter grants authority over, and the assignment does not allocate, is a defect** and MUST be recorded as an open item with a named owner and a date.

4.4 The persons MUST be named in advance

The accountable person for each decision type MUST be named in the assignment before the decision arises, and MUST NOT be selected at the moment it does. **A named deputy MUST be recorded for each**, for the reason 2.3 of [4] gives about gate roles. Decision types here arise on a cadence. A cadence does not wait for an appointment.

The release authority the deployment spine exercises at its gates is an assignment made here rather than a separate authority [4]. The spine specifies what a gate requires; this framework specifies who holds it. Where the two are described in different documents by different names, the institution has two answers to one question and will produce whichever it finds first.

4.5 Evidence

The decision-rights assignment, naming one accountable person per decision type, with deputies, dated, and traceable to the charter clause that grants the function authority over each decision type it allocates.

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5. Records (Normative)

5.1 A cadence with no meeting records is not a cadence

Every standing review the charter establishes MUST produce a record, and the records are the evidence of the cadence. A published calendar is not evidence that the meetings on it took place, and an institution whose cadence evidence is a calendar has evidenced an intention.

The rule is inherited, not invented here. MESA states it as the enforcement constraint [1]. The registry states it as the shape an evidence artifact takes [3]. Neither argument is restated. What this section fixes is which record satisfies the rule, and a calendar does not.

5.2 The cadence

The function MUST operate at least the following four rhythms.

Rhythm	Frequency	Subject	Record produced
Operations review	Weekly	Systems in flight, gate queue, open conditions, monitoring exceptions	Decisions taken, items escalated, conditions closed and opened
Risk review	Monthly	Portfolio risk position, validation findings, vendor and data exceptions, incident trend	Risk position accepted or challenged, with the accepting person named
Board report	Quarterly	The position reported to the body that granted the mandate	The report as delivered, and the body's response

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Rhythm	Frequency	Subject	Record produced
Charter refresh	Annually	The charter itself, per 2.3	Re-approval, whether or not the text changed

An institution **MAY** operate additional rhythms and **MUST** record them in the charter. **An institution MUST NOT substitute a more frequent rhythm for a less frequent one.** A weekly operations review does not discharge the monthly risk review: the first examines systems in motion, the second the portfolio position those systems produce.

The four are a floor. The source treatment specifies a daily rhythm as well and this specification does not, for the reason at Appendix A.6.

5.3 What a cadence record MUST carry

At minimum:

- the rhythm and the date;
- who attended, by name, and which named accountable persons did not;
- what was decided, and by which named person for each decision;
- what was escalated, to whom, and under which threshold;
- what was carried forward, with an owner and a date;
- the policy version in force at the time.

The policy version carries the weight, and 2.5 of [4] states why. A record showing that a person accepted a position on stated evidence is incomplete without the rules in force when they accepted it. A record series spanning a policy change and not saying so reads as one continuous regime. It was two.

5.4 A cancelled meeting produces a record

Where a scheduled cadence meeting does not take place, the function MUST record that it did not, the reason, and what was done with the business it would have transacted.

This is the requirement most likely to be dismissed as bureaucracy and the one carrying the most diagnostic weight. A cadence that quietly stops is the most common way a governance function decays, and it decays invisibly because a meeting that did not happen leaves no trace. **A gap in a record series is evidence of a gap. A record series with no gaps and no cancellations is either a function operating perfectly or a function recording selectively**, and an auditor cannot distinguish the two.

5.5 Evidence

The record of each cadence meeting held in the period, and of each scheduled meeting not held with its reason. Records MUST be retrievable by system and by date, so that what the function knew about a given system at a given time is answerable without reading the series end to end.

---

6. Escalation (Normative)

6.1 What an escalation path is

An escalation path is three things: a named recipient, a stated threshold and a stated clock. A diagram supplies none of them. A path lacking any of the three is not specified, and a matter that meets a threshold nobody owns escalates nowhere.

The charter MUST establish at least three paths.

1. **Incidents.** From detection to the incident lead, and onward to the head of the office and the escalation destination the charter names, at the severity thresholds the decision-rights assignment fixes, which the incident protocol consumes and does not define [3].

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2. **Human-review tiers.** From an automated decision the institution has bounded, to the human tier reviewing it, to the person who may release the bound. The path MUST state what the reviewer may do and what they may not.
3. **Gate disputes.** From a rejected passage, or one the accountable person declines to take, to whoever may resolve it. **The resolution MUST NOT be the substitution of a different approver for the one who declined.**

6.2 What an escalation record MUST carry

The matter, the threshold met, the time it was met, the time it was raised, the named recipient, the decision taken, and the named person who took it. Where an escalation was raised and not resolved within its stated clock, the record MUST state that and MUST name who was informed.

The clock runs from the threshold being met, not from the escalation being raised. The interval between the two is the property the record exists to expose. The interval is the finding. A record that starts at the moment of raising cannot show a delay in raising.

6.3 The escalation output the incident protocol consumes

The escalation paths and the records they produce are supplied to the incident response protocol, REG-05, as the routes along which an incident travels and as evidence during a reconstruction [3].

An escalation record SHOULD be written in a form that joins with the other evidence a reconstruction gathers. The corpus construct for this is the BOE Declaration [2]: the threshold is the boundary the escalation fixes, the decision taken is the freedom it grants, and the record is the evidence that the boundary held. Records written in that shape join to gate records, validation records and routing evidence on event identity. Records that are not will be filed alongside the rest rather than joinable with them.

6.4 Evidence

The escalation paths as established in the charter, each with recipient, threshold and clock. The escalation records for the period, including those that breached their clock.

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7. The Ninety-Day Stand-Up Path (Normative)

7.1 Four milestones, in order

An institution standing the function up from a board mandate **MUST** reach the following four milestones in this order, and **SHOULD** reach the fourth within ninety days of the mandate.

Milestone	Completed when	Artifact
1. Mandate	The governing body has directed that the function exist, in a dated instrument	The mandate
2. Charter	The body that granted the mandate has approved the charter, per Section 2	The charter
3. Office	The head and each lead are named individuals, and the decision-rights assignment allocates every decision type the charter enumerates	The staffing record and the assignment
4. First operating cadence	The first meeting of each of the weekly and monthly rhythms has been held and has produced a record, per Section 5	The first cadence records

The order is normative and the ninety days are not. An institution reaching milestone four in one hundred and fifty days has stood the function up slowly. An institution reaching milestone four without milestone two has stood up meetings.

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The common inversion is standing up the cadence before the charter, because meetings are easy to schedule and a charter requires a governing body to commit. A function that meets before it is chartered accumulates decisions taken without traceable authority, and those do not become authorized retrospectively when the charter arrives.

7.2 What this path does not specify

It specifies no week-by-week work plan, budget, technology selection, training programme or communications sequence. Material of that kind exists in the source treatment [7] and is not carried here, for the reason at Appendix A.6: **the source treatment routes approvals through committees, which 4.1 forbids**, and importing its plan would import that route.

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8. Conformance (Normative)

8.1 Self-declared, and nothing else

Conformance is **self-declared**. No conformity assessment body operates against this specification, and no third party is accredited to assess a claim made under it.

8.2 What a conformance claim requires

An institution is conformant with this specification, at a stated date, if all of the following hold.

1. **A charter exists**, dated and approved by the body that granted the mandate, containing every element at 2.2, and within its review date per 2.3.
2. **The office is staffed** with each lead at 3.3 held by a named individual, with any combination recorded, and no forbidden combination in force.
3. **The three-lines allocation is stated** in the charter as ownership, per 3.4.
4. **A decision-rights assignment exists**, allocating every decision type the charter enumerates, with exactly one named accountable person and a named deputy for each, per Section 4.
5. **Each cadence rhythm at 5.2 produced its records** for the period claimed, including records of scheduled meetings not held, per 5.4.
6. **The three escalation paths at 6.1 are established** with recipient, threshold and clock, and the escalation records for the period exist, per 6.2.

8.3 What MUST accompany a claim

A published claim MUST carry the version claimed against, the date of the evidence relied on, and the period the cadence records cover. It MUST state which leads at 3.3 are combined in one person, and MUST state whether the Sharia liaison applies.

8.4 What a conformance claim does not mean

- **It does not mean the institution is compliant** with any statute or supervisory expectation. Only a supervisor determines that.
- **It does not mean the governance function is effective.** Section 10 states what has not been tested.
- **It does not mean the institution has been assessed.** Nobody assessed it. It declared.
- **It does not mean a certification exists.** None does.
- **It does not mean the frameworks CADRE grants authority to are operating.** Those carry their own requirements and their own claims.

8.5 Lapse

An institution whose cadence records stop being produced is no longer conformant from the date production stopped, not from the date the lapse is discovered. An institution whose charter passes its review date without re-approval is no longer conformant from the review date.

A conformance claim carries the date of its evidence, and evidence has a currency. A claim that is not refreshed becomes a historical statement rather than a current one, and presenting a historical statement as a current one is a misuse of this specification.

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9. Related Work

9.1 The three lines model

The three lines model is the closest standing instrument to 3.4 and this specification does not duplicate it. The Institute of Internal Auditors issued a Statement of Position on the model on 8 July 2026 [8], replacing its 2020 position paper [9]; the refreshed statement addresses the board as its primary audience and emphasizes the distinct contribution of each role rather than a defensive posture.

The relationship runs one way. **CADRE positions the AI governance function within whatever three-lines allocation the institution already operates for non-AI risk, and extends it rather than duplicating it.** An institution standing up a separate AI risk structure alongside its existing one has two structures answering the same question. This specification states neither instrument's requirements.

9.2 Management system standards and decision-rights notations

ISO/IEC 42001 [10] specifies a management system for artificial intelligence and the NIST AI Risk Management Framework [11] specifies a risk management structure. Both address governance at institutional altitude and both leave the allocation of individual accountability to the organization. **That allocation is this framework's subject.** An institution certified to ISO/IEC 42001 may operate CADRE, or not.

Responsibility assignment notations of the RACI family are widely used, and this framework uses that vocabulary without claiming it. **What this specification adds is the constraint rather than the notation**: exactly one accountable person, named in advance, with a deputy, allocated across lifecycle phase and decision type, and forbidden to be a committee. A notation permits a committee in the accountable column. This specification does not.

9.3 Model risk supervision

Supervisory model risk guidance constrains what the function's authority must reach. In Canada, OSFI Guideline E-23 [12], published 11 September 2025 and effective 1 May 2027, extends model risk expectations to artificial intelligence and machine learning models and to models and data sourced from third parties. In the United States, SR 26-2 [13], issued 17 April 2026, supersedes and replaces SR 11-7 (2011). An institution subject to either **MUST perform its own crosswalk against the primary source in force**, and this specification states neither instrument's requirements.

9.4 The governance family

CADRE is entry REG-07 of the Defensible AI Framework Registry [3], which is the canonical source for its relationships to every framework named above. **Where this specification and the registry describe the same relationship, the registry governs**, because two documents asserting the same relationships will otherwise drift.

10. Limitations and What Has Not Been Tested

10.1 No institution unconnected to the author has been observed operating it

The framework is named and used, and **no third party has published a result obtained under it**. Everything in Sections 2 through 7 is an architectural claim. It is coherent. Whether a chartered office with named decision rights surfaces a risk earlier than a competent committee is a fact about institutions, and no institution has supplied it. There is no implementation profile, no scored instrument, and no published measurement of what the artifacts cost to produce or what they change.

10.2 The name has not been cleared

A trademark clearance search has not been completed for CADRE, and the naming rule stated under On the name is stated as a discipline rather than as the outcome of one. This specification does not assert that the mark

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is available, registrable or free of conflict. **The symbol used throughout is the unregistered-mark symbol.** It asserts a claim, not a registration. The registered-mark symbol is not applied to this or any name in the family.

The corpus already carries the same limitation against Five-Gate at [4] 8.5 and against the MESA MRM Framework; this is one more. A clearance result that goes against the name would be a change under Section 11 rather than a correction.

10.3 No charter, assignment or cadence templates are published

This specification states the requirements on a charter, a decision-rights assignment, a cadence record and an escalation record. **It does not publish templates for any of the four.**

An institution can be told what a conformant charter must contain and cannot be handed one. Two institutions operating CADRE will therefore produce artifacts that are individually conformant and not comparable with each other, which is the gap the deployment spine records against its own missing gate templates [4] 8.4.

This is a known gap and not a deliberate omission. Section 11 records the publication of templates as a minor version change, which is where it belongs.

10.4 It is calibrated to institutions large enough to staff it

The role set at 3.3 is five leads plus a head, before deputies. The registry records the same limitation against this entry [3] and it is not restated here. A small institution reading 3.3 counts six people it does not have.

An institution below that scale MUST adapt the structure and SHOULD record what it adapted, because an unadapted structure applied to a small institution produces roles nobody holds. This specification permits combination at 3.3 and forbids two combinations, and **it does not state which further compressions preserve the framework's properties and which destroy them.** That is the second most valuable addition available to a future version.

10.5 The consolidation is not executed in the source book

The consolidation recorded at registry section 6.2 has not been executed in the source treatment, which continues to assert the three former marks on its copyright page until a natural reprint [3]. **The registry, and now this specification, are the authoritative statement in the meantime.**

The rename at Appendix A adds a fourth former name to that position. A reader holding the first edition of [7] will find three framework names this specification treats as retired sections and a fourth it treats as a descriptor. Appendix A.5 is the crosswalk.

10.6 Scope: the function, not the people in it

The framework specifies the governance function. **Competency, training and the individual credentials of the people in it are outside its scope.** An institution can be fully conformant and staffed by people who cannot perform the challenge the second line position requires.

This is a genuine limit on what a conformance claim means. The claim says the structure exists and produces its artifacts. It says nothing about whether the artifacts are any good.

10.7 The specification is a single-author instrument

The author operates a consulting practice applying this framework, which is a conflict of interest stated here. The mitigations are the lesser ones available to any single-author instrument: the identifier cannot change, the falsification condition is published, the limitations are stated rather than inferred, and the registry rather than this document governs the framework's place in the architecture. **None of these makes the specification independent.**

10.8 What would falsify the framework

The framework is falsified if institutions operating a chartered office with a documented single-accountable decision-rights assignment and a recorded cadence are found to escalate AI risks no earlier, and resolve them no more consistently, than institutions handling AI governance within existing risk committees without a distinct structure.

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The claim under test is that named decision rights change when a risk surfaces and who it reaches. The comparison is deliberately against a competent alternative rather than no governance at all: an institution running AI risk through a well-functioning existing risk committee is a serious competitor for the same job and may be faster.

Three narrower findings would falsify parts of it. If institutions naming a single accountable person per decision type resolve disputes no faster, and reverse decisions no less often, than institutions assigning accountability to committees, 4.1 costs two appointments and buys nothing. If functions recording cancelled meetings detect their own decay no earlier than functions that do not, 5.4 is a record nobody needs. And if escalation records are found in practice not to join with gate and validation records during a reconstruction, the join at 6.3 is asserted and not real.

10.9 Research questions

1. Does naming a single accountable person per decision type change the outcome relative to committee accountability on the same decisions, and by what measure?
2. What does producing the five artifacts cost, and at what institutional scale does it stop being proportionate to the risk?
3. Which compressions of the role set preserve the framework's properties in an institution too small to staff it?
4. Does the record of cancelled cadence meetings predict governance decay earlier than any other available signal?

A reader able to answer any of these from real institutional evidence is invited to make contact through the ORCID record in the front matter.

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11. Versioning

The major number changes when a change could make a previously conformant function non-conformant: an artifact is added to Section 8.2, a cadence rhythm is added to 5.2, a requirement is tightened, the role set at 3.3 changes, or the canonical name changes again.

The minor number changes for additions and clarifications that cannot: a corrected limitation, a new mapping to an external instrument, the publication of templates, or the resolution of the clearance limitation at 10.2.

The registry identifier REG-07 is normative and MUST NOT change. It did not change at the rename recorded at Appendix A and does not change at any future one. A framework retired in a future registry version retains its identifier, marked retired rather than reused [3].

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12. References

Every external reference was re-verified against a live primary source on 8 September 2026, each with a deliberate failing control, because a check that cannot fail proves nothing. Two checks reached an authoritative substitute rather than the page the citation points to, and are recorded as such: ISO's own page for [10] refused the request, so the edition and publication date were confirmed from the IEC webstore, IEC being one of the two issuing bodies named in the reference; and the day precision in [11] comes from NIST's own publication record, the document face carrying the month only. Every corpus reference below is a **concept DOI**, which always resolves to the latest version.

[1] Khan, N. A. (2026). *The MESA Framework: A Four-Altitude Diagnostic Model for Institutional AI Governance. Framework Specification.* Zenodo. Concept DOI https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22109836

[2] Khan, N. A. (2026). *A Pattern Language for Production LLM Platforms: Governed Routing, Agent Orchestration, and AI-Native Delivery. Pattern Language Specification.* Zenodo. Concept DOI https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22109864

[3] Khan, N. A. (2026). *The Defensible AI Framework Registry: Canonical Names, Definitions and Relationships for the Governed Production AI Discipline. Registry Specification.* Zenodo. Concept DOI https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22170112

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[4] Khan, N. A. (2026). *The Five-Gate Deployment Model: A Deployment Discipline for AI Systems. Deployment Model Specification.* Zenodo. Concept DOI https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22170122

[5] Khan, N. A. (2026). *The Sharia AI Compliance Framework: A Dual-Authority Governance Architecture for Islamic Finance. Framework Specification.* Zenodo. Concept DOI https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22170143

[6] Khan, N. A. (2026). *The AI Vendor Due-Diligence Questionnaire: AVRF Instrument for Third-Party AI Systems, Models and APIs. Questionnaire Specification.* Zenodo. Concept DOI https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22170146

[7] Khan, N. A. (2026). *AI Governance and Compliance Frameworks for the Middle East: The Enterprise Playbook.* First Edition. iSystematic Inc. ISBN 978-1-0678960-1-0. The source treatment is chapters 10 and 11, read with the consolidation notice at [3] 6.2. Appendix A.6 records where the two diverge.

[8] Institute of Internal Auditors (2026). *Assurance and Advice in Support of Effective Governance: Three Lines Model. Statement of Position.* Published 8 July 2026. Replaces the position paper at [9].

[9] Institute of Internal Auditors (2020). *The IIA's Three Lines Model: An Update of the Three Lines of Defense.* Position paper, 2020, updated September 2024. **Superseded by [8]**, and cited only because prior corpus material, including the reference list of the registry [1], cites this version.

[10] International Organization for Standardization and International Electrotechnical Commission (2023). *ISO/IEC 42001:2023, Information technology. Artificial intelligence. Management system.* First edition, December 2023.

[11] National Institute of Standards and Technology (2023). *Artificial Intelligence Risk Management Framework (AI RMF 1.0).* NIST AI 100-1, 26 January 2023.

[12] Office of the Superintendent of Financial Institutions, Canada (2025). *Guideline E-23, Model Risk Management (2027).* Published 11 September 2025, effective 1 May 2027.

[13] Board of Governors of the Federal Reserve System, Office of the Comptroller of the Currency and Federal Deposit Insurance Corporation (2026). *SR 26-2, Revised Guidance on Model Risk Management.* Issued 17 April 2026. Supersedes and replaces SR 11-7 (2011) and SR 21-8 (2021).

One verification could not be completed. No trademark register was reachable in a way that discriminated a genuine record from a deliberately invented control, so **no claim about the availability, registrability or ownership of the name CADRE appears in this document**, and 10.2 records that as an open limitation rather than a closed question.

Appendix A. Provenance of the Name

Recorded so that work published under the former name remains citable. **A former name is not an error in the work that used it.**

A.1 The rename

Former canonical name	Current canonical name	Effective	Recorded at
AI Governance Operating Model, deliberately unmarked	CADRE™	1 September 2026	This appendix

"AI Governance Operating Model" is retired as the name and retained as the descriptor. It is not a former name in the sense the registry's Appendix A.2 uses for a name withdrawn from use. It remains the phrase that says what the framework is, and the canonical first mention pairs the two: *CADRE™, the AI Governance Operating Model*.

The short form recorded at registry 4.7.2, *the Operating Model*, is replaced by *CADRE* for new work.

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A.2 The identifier does not change

The registry identifier remains REG-07. The registry requires that a rename record the former name and **MUST NOT change the identifier** [3] section 11.2, and it further provides that a change to a canonical name is a **major** version change to the registry itself [3] section 11.1. Both apply here. The name changed; the identifier did not; the registry that carries the entry goes to a major version.

This is the mechanism that makes the rename survivable. Every cross-reference in the corpus resolves through the identifier rather than through the name.

A.3 Citations of the former name in published, immutable records

The former name is cited in records deposited on Zenodo, which are immutable once published. Those citations cannot be corrected and do not need to be: the registry [3] carries it at the entry at 4.7, the register rows at 5.2, the consolidation notice at 6.2, the deliberately-unmarked table at Appendix A.6 and the machine-readable layer; the deployment spine [4] carries it as the framework granting its release authority; and MESA [1] carries it in the Layer 3 pillar 1 disambiguation, which names the framework in order to distinguish it from the pillar.

Every one of those citations resolves through REG-07, which is unchanged, and each remains a correct citation of the work published under the former name. A reader arriving at any of them from a search for the former name reaches the right framework by the right route.

A.4 The reasoning at registry 4.7.4, rewritten

The registry recorded, at section 4.7.4, why the framework was unmarked, and recorded explicitly that the question of coining and marking a distinctive name **remained open rather than settled**. That question is now closed. The reasoning is rewritten here rather than deleted, because the record of why it was open is part of the answer.

What the original reasoning got right, and this specification keeps. The phrase *AI governance operating model* is descriptive and in common industry use, and a mark asserted on it would be hard to register and weak to enforce. **A descriptive phrase is a poor mark precisely because it is a good descriptor**: the generality that makes it immediately understood makes it impossible to own, and an attempt to own it would have to argue that a reader meeting the phrase in ordinary use was meeting a brand. Asserting a mark on it would also have invited the criticism the consolidation at registry 6.2 exists to remove, which is that the portfolio inflated its count by marking descriptions.

What has changed. The original reasoning treated the choice as binary: mark the descriptive phrase, or mark nothing. It is not binary. Coining a distinctive name and keeping the phrase as the descriptor takes the enforceable position without giving up the readable one.

What has not changed, and this is the load-bearing part. The value of this framework sits in its artifacts and not in the exclusivity of its name. The charter, the decision-rights assignment, the cadence records and the escalation records are what an institution can be held to. A mark protects the name under which those requirements are published. It does not make the requirements better and confers no advantage on an institution operating them. This specification is licensed CC BY 4.0 for that reason: the framework may be implemented, taught, assessed against and extended by anyone, with attribution, and the mark grants no rights over any of that.

What remains open. No clearance search has been run, recorded as a limitation at 10.2 rather than resolved here. The registry entry's mark-status field changes from unmarked to trademarked at registry version 2.0, and its rationale field carries this appendix by reference.

A.5 Four former names, not three

The registry records three names absorbed into this framework by the consolidation at section 6.2. The rename adds a fourth to the entry's former-names list, of a different kind.

Former name	Kind	What it became	Recorded at
Governance Office Blueprint	Absorbed, retired as a separate name	The Structure part of the definition, specified at Section 3 of this document	[3] 6.2
RACI-AI Matrix	Absorbed, retired as a separate name	The Decision rights part, specified at Section 4	[3] 6.2

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Former name	Kind	What it became	Recorded at
Governance Cadence Framework	Absorbed, retired as a separate name	The Cadence part, specified at Sections 5 and 6	[3] 6.2
AI Governance Operating Model	Renamed, retained as the descriptor	The descriptor accompanying CADRE™ at first mention	A.1 above

The first three **MUST NOT** be used for new work, and any surface presenting them as current frameworks is out of date with the registry. **The fourth is different.** It is not withdrawn but demoted from name to descriptor, and a surface using it as a description remains correct.

A.6 Crosswalk to the source treatment

The source treatment is chapters 10 and 11 of [7]. **This specification and the registry entry govern; the source treatment does not.** Four divergences are recorded rather than reconciled silently, because a reader holding the book will otherwise conclude that one document is wrong without knowing which.

Subject	Source treatment [7]	This specification	Which governs
Cadence	Daily, weekly, monthly and quarterly rhythms. No annual charter refresh	Weekly, monthly, quarterly and an annual charter refresh. No daily rhythm	This specification, per 5.2
Approval	Approval authority for use cases and deployments vested in the AI Governance Committee	Exactly one named person accountable per decision type; a committee MUST NOT be accountable	This specification, per 4.1, which restates registry 3.3
Role set	Chief AI Officer, Model Risk Manager, AI Ethics Lead, Data Steward	Head of the office, and leads for model risk, data, vendor and incident, plus a Sharia liaison where REG-08 applies	This specification, per 3.3
Gate names	Five gates named Use Case Approval, Design Approval and so on	The gates are not this framework's to name. G1 to G5 are specified at [4] and this framework assigns who holds them	[4], per 4.4

Two of the four are substantive rather than editorial. **The committee-approval route is forbidden here**, so an institution that implemented the chapters as written holds an assignment this specification does not accept, and 4.2 states the remedy: name the chair as the accountable individual. **The daily rhythm is dropped** because continuous monitoring is a property of the monitoring stack rather than of the governance function, and what happens when it fires is specified by the incident protocol at REG-05 rather than by a governance meeting.

The consolidation has not been executed in the source book, which continues to assert the three former marks on its copyright page until a natural reprint. That is recorded at 10.5.

Appendix B. Publication Provenance

B.1 What this document is. The first public version of this specification. **Not peer reviewed.** Deposited on Zenodo, which confers a DOI, a timestamp and citability. **Zenodo does not confer standard status, and nothing in this document uses the word standard for itself.**

B.2 Relationship to prior publication. The framework was named and used before this specification, principally in [7], under the name recorded at Appendix A.1. Its registry entry at [3] 4.7 was until now the most complete normative statement of it in citable form. This document is its first standalone, versioned statement, and the first under the name CADRE.

B.3 No preprint. No preprint identifier exists and no preprint relation is asserted in this record's metadata.

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B.4 Publication order. This record publishes with the four other deposits closing the registry's remaining `source-treatment` and `instrument-pending` entries. It publishes after registry version 1.0 [3] and before registry version 2.0, in which the entry's specification status moves to `deposited`, its canonical name changes, and the change is classified as normative in the registry changelog. Until then, **registry entry REG-07 as published at version 1.0 remains the canonical statement of this framework's relationships and governs where the two describe the same relationship**, and a reader will find that entry carrying the former name.

B.5 Figures. The figure this specification references is **not deposited in this record**. It is deposited separately, carries its own DOI, and is cited at the point of use in the same manner as any other external work. The caption at 3.6 is written to carry the argument on its own, so a reader who does not retrieve the figure loses an illustration rather than a requirement. **No normative content is stated only in a figure.**

B.6 Verification method. Every external reference in Section 12 was checked against a live primary source with a deliberate failing control, on 8 September 2026. Where a source could not be reached in a way that discriminated a real identifier from an invented one, no claim resting on it appears in this document. The one such case is the trademark register, recorded in the note at the end of Section 12 and at 10.2.

B.7 Funding and conflicts. The work is unfunded. The author operates a consulting practice applying this framework, which is a conflict of interest stated here and at 10.7.

Document History

Version	Date	Summary
1.0	8 September 2026	First public version. The five artifacts; the charter requirement and annual refresh; the authority position and the absence of an inbound edge; single accountable person per decision; the cadence and the record rule including cancellations; three escalation paths; the ninety-day path; self-declared conformance; the rename from the AI Governance Operating Model, with the identifier REG-07 unchanged

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About the Author

Nabeel Khan is an enterprise AI architect and governance advisor, and Founder & Solutions Architect at iSystematic Inc. He has spent twenty-five years architecting enterprise data and machine-learning systems in government, healthcare, financial services and telecommunications across three continents, grounded in TOGAF, DMBOK, ISO 27001 and SOC 2.

He works on governed production AI; systems whose authority is bounded by the architecture, whose decisions carry the evidence needed to defend them, and whose behaviour the institution can explain afterwards. The frameworks specified here, and the regulatory knowledge behind them, are published as machine-accessible AI expertise and are callable over MCP without a key at mcp.nabeelkhan.com/api/mcp, so a reader may query this specification's contents directly and receive answers carrying their source.

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  Five Artifacts. (Version 1.0). Zenodo.
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```

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